



SuperTalent Picox

Buffalo, one of the leading memory solution companies, has released 5 mm long USB drives, which still manage to pack in 16GB of memory – housed in the plug itself



IronKey Protection

IronKey offers military grade protection on its USB drives to consumers. It has released a new series of USB drives, in the \$200 range, which use a technology known as cryptochip to secure the data

Flash Drive Test

UBI6 than with the Transcend.

Continuing the trend, this drive is also rescued by its software. The JetFlash Elite software can take care of backups, email, favourites, 128-bit encryption, and PC locks. The Transcend is available for an MRP of Rs. 2,500, though market prices should be a lot cheaper – half that at least. Based on the MRPs, it would be ridiculous to choose this drive over the SanDisk Ultra Backup; however, you're going to have to consider the market prices.

32 GB

Obese options

This segment is targeted at all those of you who just have to have tonnes of space, or carry a lot of data around with you. With 64 GB drives coming out, expect prices here to fall steadily.

OCZ ATV 32GB

This segment interests me the most, because I use a lot of portable applications, and just have to carry my email and work around with me. The OCZ ATV demands attention, with a black and blue rubber body. The rubber is hard and feels durable, and acts like a shock resistor. The rubber is also specially designed to make this drive waterproof – something I tested by holding it under a running tap. The rubber is like a duck's back, with no water clinging to it, and a quick wipe on my jeans almost completely dries it. Although I did want to chuck it into a bucketful of water for about an hour, I resisted, mainly because I still had to test it.

I'm assuming that ATV stands for all-terrain vehicle, and this drive certainly is one. Like the 8 GB Corsair Voyager, I played hacky-sack with this one too (after testing it), and although it doesn't bounce as much, or as weirdly, as the Voyager, the ATV still stands tough. It's by far the best built drive of this test.

In terms of performance, however, this is more a Hummer than a Ferrari. The assorted tests especially kill this drive – like a Hummer it probably needs a lot of refuelling pit stops between file transfers. This drive was the slowest across all categories for the assorted read and write tests. The sequential tests didn't reveal much better results, with the drive yielding the second slowest write time and third slowest read time.

What this drive does offer, however, is the lowest cost per GB of storage. At Rs. 3,900, you're going to be hard pressed to find a drive of this capacity for any cheaper. So if you want something that will last a lifetime, really cheap, and don't mind spending half that lifetime waiting for transfers to finish, this drive is worth a look at.

Kingston Data Traveler 150 32 GB

This is a weird looking drive, with a very odd colour. It's



got a tiny honeycomb pattern that's somewhere between red and orange. Depending on the lighting conditions, this drive looks either orange or peach – not my favourite fruit colours. The body is hard plastic, and seems to be durable, though I bet I could crush the plastic by pressing really hard. The drive has a cap holder design on the back, and a key ring, which seems only limited in its usefulness. Overall, it's one of the better built plastic drives, but I'm still personally biased towards rubber or metal.

All this negativity stopped when I connected the drive up and started the tests. It's not the fastest in

any of the tests, but it's a very consistent performer. Across the capacities, it's beaten only by the Kingston HyperX in the sequential tests and the assorted write, and comes in third in the assorted read tests, behind the Apacer AH522 and the SanDisk Cruzer, respectively.

Although not as cheap, in terms of price per GB as the OCZ, it's still pretty good value for money, especially when you consider its performance. It marginally lost out to the SanDisk Cruzer as the value for money pick, because of the lack of a software bundle and capabilities. It's a good standalone drive though, and wins the Editor's Pick award, because this editor feels that a 32 GB pen drive is a must have.

Memory cards

Almost every device, these days, use memory cards to enhance their data storage capacity. From mobile phones to digital cameras, and some PMPs to hand-held console devices, everything needs memory cards these days.

For this test, we received memory cards in four categories: Compact Flash, Micro SD, SD and Memory Stick Pro Duo. These four categories pretty much cover every type of memory that you might need for a modern gadget.

Compact Flash

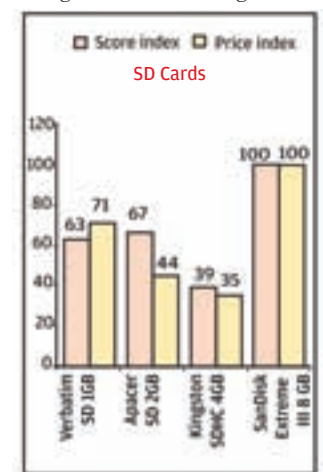
Mostly used in digital cameras, Compact Flash (CF) seems to offer the best performance of the memory cards. We received 8 memory cards for this test: four from Kingston, three from SanDisk and one from Verbatim.

I'm only tested one parameter, and that's real-world performance. The CF cards Digit received ranged from 2 GB

to 32 GB, and my tests showed that although read speeds are quite comparable, write speeds can throw a spanner into the works. Interestingly, since the most common uses for these cards are in compact digital cameras and DSLRs, write speeds become more important as the megapixel count goes up. With 10 mega pixels almost the norm these days, at least the sequential write speed for the card becomes very important. I ensured that I scored the cards accordingly, giving more importance to sequential speeds than assorted speeds.

The fastest card overall was the SanDisk Extreme IV CF 16 GB. The two Kingston brothers, the Ultimate 266X 4 GB and 8 GB were a very close second and third. The SanDisk Extreme IV gets the Best Performance award in the CF category.

If you look at the comparison graph, you'll notice that the Extreme IV is only marginally better than the two Kingstons. The Ultimate 266X 8 GB, however, has the bigger difference in performance and price between the two, and you'd expect it to get our Best Buy award. That's not to be though, because the Kingston



COMPACT FLASH CARDS

Compact flash cards are pretty much always going to be used in digital cameras. This means that assorted reads and writes are of less importance, because you're mostly interested in sequential writes, as your camera tries to write the image it's just clicked to the card. Even when reading (previewing images), the camera is going to try and read a large image to display on the screen – sequential again. We gave more importance to sequential reads and writes for this category.

Kingston Data Traveler 150 32 GB

